

THE CRYPTS OF KELEMVOR

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INTRODUCTION

“The Crypts of Kelemvor” is a one-shot DUNGEONS & DRAGONS adventure for characters of levels 3 to 5, adapted from a quest in Neverwinter online. This scenario sees the adventuring party given an important quest to collect a number of broken magical seals and to light a number of magical braziers, all of which once protected the crypts of Kelemvor. In so doing, they can help to quell a devastating uprising of undead—organized by a powerful lich named Idris bent on destroying the city of Neverwinter.

RUNNING THE ADVENTURE

This is a classic dungeon delve, but with a number of MMORPG twists. The characters are tasked with finding and collecting items, but must also “click” parts of the environment as they explore—the braziers whose magical light is anathema to undead. In addition to the normal tricks the adventurers can use as they face off against the undead of the crypts, the light of the sacred braziers can be used as a weapon. Additionally, the end of the scenario gives the characters a chance to interact with another adventuring party—a band known as the Grave Robbers.

Sacred Braziers of Balance. When one of these magical braziers is lit, its fire bursts forth in a bright blue

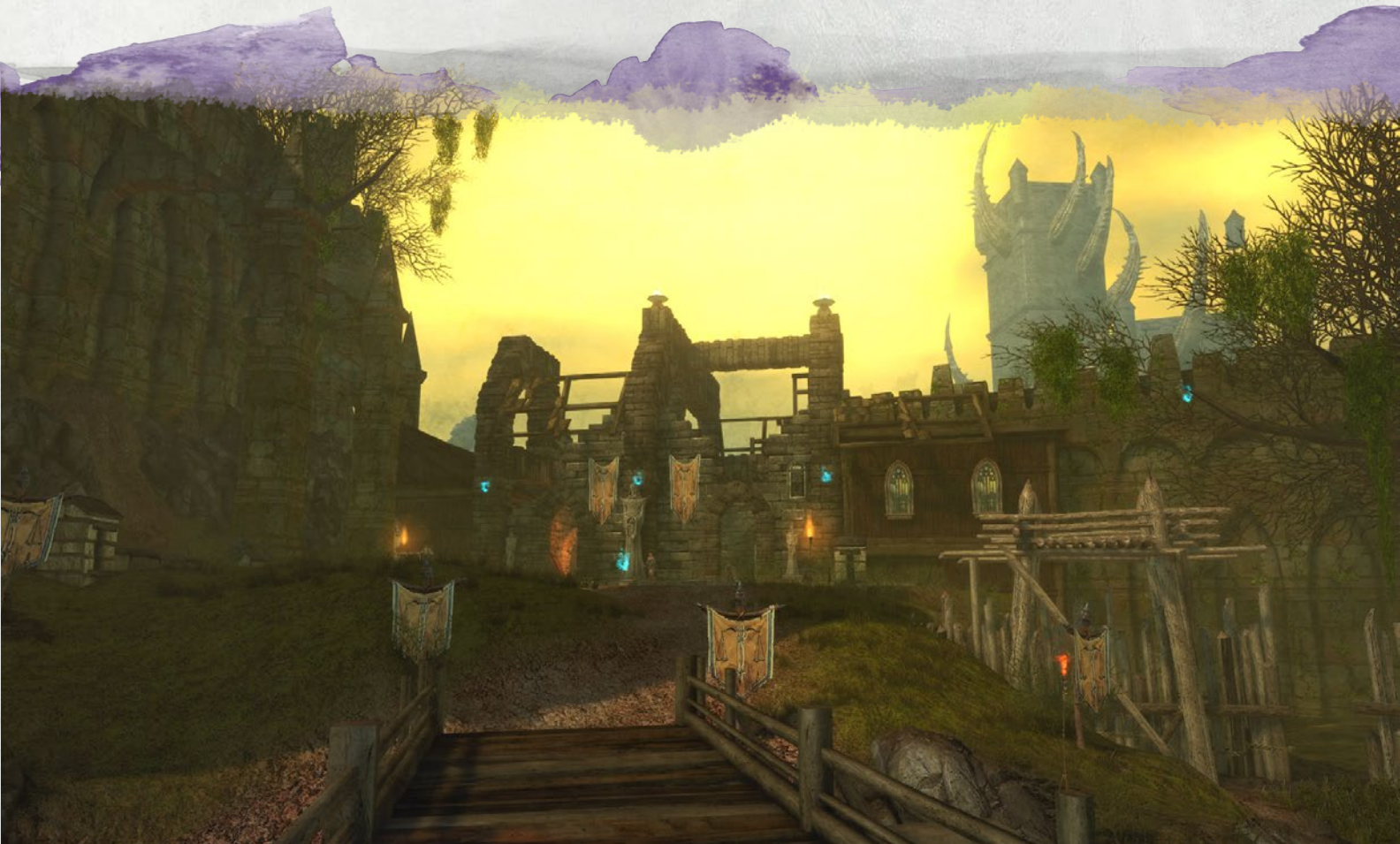
flame that fills a 25-foot-radius area with bright blue-white light. For the first 3 rounds after a brazier is lit, any undead creature that starts its turn within the brazier’s light takes 16 (3d10) radiant damage—presenting a significant threat to such creatures. The length of time it takes to light the braziers is the wild card. A character adjacent to a brazier must use an action to light it, but doing so requires a special striking rod and stone, as well as a successful DC 12 Dexterity check.

The Grave Robbers. Before the main boss fight at the end of the scenario, the characters come across an adventuring party known as the Grave Robbers. Three of that party’s original four members face off against the characters (with their cleric having been found eaten in an earlier part of the dungeon). You can play the Grave Robbers as greedy and spoiling for a fight, or you can portray them as pragmatic and willing to work with the characters to complete their exploration of the dungeon.

Monsters. Statistics blocks for the undead and other monsters of the crypts appear in an appendix at the end of the adventure.

EBON DOWNS

Deep in the Silverwisp Swamp off the southern High Road lie the burial grounds known as Ebon Downs. Here, many generations of local folk have been laid to rest, interred within barrows, crypts, and tombs.





The villagers of Grimhollow have watched over these grounds for many years, with each generation passing on the duties to their children. Under their watchful eyes, the Ebon Downs have seen peace.

But one night, that peace was shattered forever. Whether due to a lapse in Grimhollow's vigil or some unknown power, the dead rose in force from the burial grounds and attacked the village, overwhelming its citizens. Those few lucky enough to escape spoke of a dark magic that caused those killed in the attack to rise as undead almost as soon as the life had left their bodies.

The only thing left standing as a beacon of hope in Ebon Downs is the rundown fortress-temple of Kelemvor—a literal wall dividing the now-swamp-encroached village from the great barrows and the graveyard. Here, the priests of Kelemvor still inter the dead, making sure they don't rise. The doomguides, clerics, and paladins dedicated to the god of the dead have pledged their lives in restoring the balance of Ebon Downs. But they are fewer and fewer every day, and have begun to call out across Faerûn for help.

ADVENTURE HOOK

If you want to play "The Crypts of Kelemvor" as a side trek in a larger adventure, you can look for ways to tie the quest into that adventure. Whatever way you customize it, the characters are approached by an acolyte of Kelemvor petitioning for aid to the temple. A token payment of 20 gp is offered, in addition to free travel and food—and the promise of burial if things go badly. But of more interest to adventurers is the acolyte's promise that any gems, magic, or other wealth found within the crypts can be kept, since the dead no longer need such things.

SEALING THE CRYPTS OF KELEMVOR

When the players are ready to begin the adventure, read or paraphrase the following.

As you enter what is left of the rundown temple of Kelemvor, you feel a strange wave of warmth pass through your body.

Any cleric or paladin in the party will recognize that the characters have just passed through a protective ward of some kind.

The temple is small, and is missing part of its roof and one wall. A priest of Kelemvor tiredly stands watch, looking out over the barrows beyond, and an armored cleric stands in the center of the area next to a campfire. The cleric looks forlorn until he sees you, at which point his smile brightens and he beckons you over to him. He introduces himself as Doomguide Soulhearth—the one who sent out the request for aid.

Soulhearth is not the most talkative person, and he gets straight to the point. "This temple of Kelemvor, our fortress, is our stronghold against the lich Idris and its army of undead. But it is not as secure as it should be. Grave robbers have broken into the crypts beneath the temple, and have broken several of the mystical seals that ensure those who are buried there remain at rest.

"I need you to enter the crypt, relight the sacred braziers that will destroy the undead, and bring back the broken seals. I can then repair them, while the holy fires from the braziers will keep any more undead from entering the crypt."

By accepting Doomguide Soulhearth's quest, the characters will help resanctify the crypts beneath the shrine of Kelemvor. Their goal is to collect all the broken seals and to relight all the braziers found in the crypts.





FEATURES OF THE CRYPTS

The crypts of Kelemvor are on three levels, broken out into separate chambers and hallways. All levels are connected by stairs, and the areas of each level are separated by portcullis gates and stone doors.

The key objects in the crypts are the statues of Kelemvor that once held the magic seals (currently broken), the *braziers of balance*, and lots of sarcophagi.

Broken Seals. Each of the broken seals that the characters must collect is a piece of carved marble scribed with the symbol of Kelemvor, and weighing about 4 pounds. All the seals were once held by statues of Kelemvor scattered around the crypts.

Doors and Gates. The areas of the crypts are separated by either iron portcullis gates or stone doors. The portcullis gates allow characters to see through them into the areas beyond. Most doors and gates are opened magically using levers on the “front side” of the door, closest to the entrance to the dungeon. This design was intended to allow areas of the crypts to be closed off from the outside if needed.

Pulling a lever to raise or lower a door or gate is an action. Once open, a door or gate stays open until

the lever is pulled again, or unless a door closes automatically as a security measure. If the characters are worried about someone closing the doors behind them, an open door can be held open by wedging a spike or similar object between it and the adjacent wall with a successful DC 12 Strength check. Unless otherwise noted, a door that has been closed can be forced open manually with a DC 25 Strength check, or can be opened with a *knock* spell or similar magic.

All portcullis gates in the crypts creak and grind loudly when raised. The stone doors open with a loud scraping sound.

Ceilings. Unless otherwise indicated, corridors and rooms in the crypts have ten-foot-high ceilings.

Light. Many of the areas on the first level are lit by magical torches imbued with *continual flame*. In other areas (including both the lower levels), there is no light except what the characters bring with them.

Sarcophagi. Numerous stone sarcophagi are set throughout the crypts. Unless otherwise indicated, all are closed. Any closed sarcophagus can be opened with a successful DC 20 Strength check, but contains only moldering bones.

AREA 1: ENTRY CHAMBER

When the characters enter the crypts, read or paraphrase the following.

A steep set of stairs leads sixty feet down to the east of the temple, to a wooden door where a Kelemvorite priest waits. He unlocks the door and beckons you through, handing over a small candle lantern, a heavy striking stone, and a steel rod the size of a large dagger. "Only the spark of this rod and stone can light the *braziers of balance*," he says dutifully. "May Kelemvor and Selûne protect you."

The door shuts loudly behind you as the last of your group passes through it, and the sound of the lock being turned on the other side is ominous. You stand in a short hallway. To the south, a thick metal portcullis gate is rusted shut, showing only a dark corridor beyond. To the north, the hallway opens up into a small room.

A burned-down campfire on the east side of the room suggests that this area was once a guard post of some sort. Next to the fire is a cloth knapsack that holds treasure left behind by a priest who once stood guard here.

A large stone door with no handles stands to the north, with a large brass lever on the wall beside it. When the lever is pulled, a disturbingly loud scraping sound rings out. Dust billows as the thick stone door slides upward, revealing the area beyond. A magical torch around the corner of the hallway lights the way forward.

TREASURE

Within the knapsack, the characters find a *potion of healing* that has the scent of brandy.

AREA 2: CENTRAL INTERSECTION

Two doors and an open corridor give the characters a choice of directions from this area.

Two doors stand ahead of you—a metal portcullis gate to the west, and a stone door straight ahead to the north. Looking through the portcullis, another corridor extends some twenty feet before making a T-intersection. A brass lever stands beside the portcullis on the west wall.

Where the passageway opens up to the east, it reveals both a larger room ahead and a statue of the god Kelemvor, its hands open as if it were holding something. A piece of carved marble sits on the floor at the statue's feet. Opposite the statue is a small alcove set with a pile of humanoid bones.

Pulling the lever raises the creaking portcullis, but there is no sign of a mechanism for the stone door. No action or magic available to the characters can open the door, and any ability checks made to search or open it result in failure. (This door opens automatically after the characters turn a special key in area 8.)

The bones are the remnants of undead skeletons destroyed by the Grave Robbers when they recently passed this way.

Broken Seal. The piece of carved marble at the feet of the statue is the first of the crypt's broken seals.

AREA 3: MAIN CRYPT

This huge chamber is supported by arched pillars, and features a ceiling ten feet high. Three ornate sarcophagi stand along the far wall, one of which has had its lid removed. Two torches along the side walls fill the room with magical light, revealing open doors along the north and south walls.

In the center of the room, a waist-high marble brazier is carved with the symbol of Kelemvor—and has a mutilated body sprawled before it. Wood is stacked and ready for lighting within the brazier, suggesting that the body might have been an acolyte attempting to light it. A scroll lies on the floor next to the body.

With a successful DC 13 Wisdom (Perception) check, a character notices crouched figures lying in wait within the shadowed spaces between the sarcophagi.





ZOMBIE HORDE

As soon as any character moves past the pillars closest to the doorway, eight **zombies** rise up from the shadows and attack. For a 4th-level party, use eleven zombies. For a 5th-level party, use fifteen zombies.

The players should instinctively recognize that this is a potentially overwhelming group of foes—and should remember that focusing on lighting the brazier will aid their efforts to defeat the undead.

The zombies are not smart enough to recognize the destructive potential of the brazier, and they attempt to fight within its light even as that light destroys them.

DOORS

Stone doors lead into areas 4 and 5, both of them already raised. Each door has a lever beside it that can be used to lower and raise it.

TREASURE

The characters can claim the *spell scroll of prayer of healing* dropped by the acolyte. Additionally, a search of the acolyte's body reveals an additional striking stone and steel rod, letting two characters attempt to light a brazier at the same time.

AREA 4: TRAPPED TOMB

Pressure plates (marked as triangles on the map) and a nonfunctioning trap in this room are not a threat, but should hopefully make the characters nervous as they explore. There is nothing of value in this room.

This small chamber features a single sarcophagus, more ornate than those seen in the larger crypt. A destroyed zombie is sprawled at the foot of the sarcophagus, its splintered skull all but removed by some massive object. In front of you, you see that object—a spear coming out of one of two holes in the wall, which must have once been part of a trap guarding this area.

AREA 5: WIGHT TOMB

This chamber features ornately carved bas reliefs along the walls, showing the symbol of Kelemvor alongside magical inscriptions. The same inscriptions cover a sarcophagus against the far wall, which is far more ornate than those seen in the main crypt. The sarcophagus is set with large red gems just beneath its lid.

A *detect magic* spell or similar magic reveals the presence of warding and binding spells within the chamber.

If any character touches the sarcophagus, its lid suddenly bursts off. Any character within 5 feet of the sarcophagus must succeed on a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw or take 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage and be knocked prone as the lid slams to the floor.

WIGHT ATTACK

When the sarcophagus lid comes off, a **wight** in gleaming knight's armor stands up within and leaps to the attack. At the same time, the room's magical wards fill the area with a sickly, pulsing red light—and cause the door to slam shut unless it has been spiked open.

The wight is weakened by the warding spells in the room, imposing disadvantage on its attack rolls. The wards also reduce it to 25 hit points for a 3rd-level party, or 35 hit points for a 4th-level party. Give it full hit points if facing a 5th-level party.

WARDS

The magical wards are a boon to the characters, but their pulsing light can be distracting. Any creature that starts its turn in the room must succeed on a DC 10 Intelligence saving throw or have disadvantage on attack rolls until the start of its next turn.

DEALING WITH THE DOOR

Any character standing in the entrance to this area when the door falls must decide which side of the door to move to. The character must also succeed on a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or take 5 (1d10) bludgeoning damage and be knocked prone.

Any characters left in area 3 when the door falls can pull the lever to open it and join the fight. If all the characters are in area 5, the door can be opened manually (see “Features of the Crypts,” above).

After the fight, a successful DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation) check can be made to examine the door mechanism and locate a hidden latch that opens the door from inside. This check cannot be made in combat.

TREASURE

The sarcophagus is set with four large sardonyx gemstones worth 10 gp each, all of which can easily be pried out.

AREA 6: DOUBLE DOORS

An intersection of corridors features two stone doors with a lever between them, a sarcophagus in an alcove, and a statue of Kelemvor with a broken seal in its hands.

Nothing hinders the characters from easily claiming this seal—unless they open the doors first. Pulling the lever opens both doors simultaneously, revealing the entrance to area 7 as well as this area—a web-filled chamber whose occupants are not happy to be disturbed.

SPIDER HUNT

The side chamber is the nest of three **giant wolf spiders**, all of which attack at once. For a 4th-level party, give each spider 18 hit points. For a 5th-level party, give each spider 23 hit points.

If any spider is reduced to 5 or fewer hit points, it scrambles to the back of the side chamber and disappears up one of several rough, narrow tunnels leading to the creatures' hunting grounds on the surface.

TREASURE

Any search of the webs in the spiders' nest uncovers a purse holding 15 gp, as well as a fine shortsword with a silver handle and a tooled silver scabbard, probably of drow make and worth 20 gp.

AREA 7: SIDE CRYPT

A statue of Kelemvor with a broken seal at its feet stands along the east wall, while a brazier stands along the west wall. A tattered banner bearing the symbol of Kelemvor hangs on the wall above the brazier.

Four ornate stone sarcophagi stand in the corners of the room, and in an alcove near the entrance. The sarcophagus in the far corner appears to have been broken in half.

A successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check reveals movement within the broken sarcophagus.

RAGING ZOMBIE

When any character moves more than halfway into the room, an enraged zombie leaps out of the broken sarcophagus, howling in hunger and racing toward the characters.

Use the statistics of an **ogre zombie** for this more advanced foe, but the zombie is a Medium creature. For



a 4th-level party, increase the zombie's Armor Class to 9. For a 5th-level party, increase the zombie's Armor Class to 10.

TREASURE

The broken sarcophagus holds three tattered devotional scrolls (worth 10 gp total to a temple), and a silver necklace featuring a symbol of Torm (50 gp).

AREA 8: CHAPEL

The characters are likely to see this area in two stages, interrupted by a fight with the chapel's skeletal guardians.

The corridor opens up to a large chamber with the look of a chapel. Its arched ceiling rises to a height of thirty feet, and magical light shines from the north. The southwest corner of the chamber holds seven plain sarcophagi with wooden coffins stacked between them, many of those rotten and broken open. A large support pillar has a statue of Kelemvor next to it, with a broken seal at its feet. Bones are scattered everywhere, but of more immediate concern are the skeletons that step out from behind the pillar, racing forward to attack.

WANDERING SKELETONS

The six **skeletons** in the initial part of the room attack any creatures they can see, and should interfere with the characters' attempts to claim the broken seal or push farther into the room.

For a 4th-level party, use eight skeletons. For a 5th-level party, use fourteen skeletons.

GETTING TO THE BRAZIER

Characters who move far enough into the room to see the brazier on the dais will likely get the idea to rush for that area ahead of the skeletons, then light the brazier as the undead close in. Two things stand in their way, though—the zombies in the western alcove, and a spike trap at the top of the dais stairs (in the square indicated on the map).

FURTHER EXPLORATION

As the characters move farther into the room (whether during the skeleton fight or after that fight is done), reveal the details of the rest of the chapel. Depending on where the characters go, you might read or paraphrase only parts of the following text.

Wide alcoves before the dais are each set with a stone sarcophagus and lit by a magical torch. The western alcove is occupied by zombies, hunched over something on the floor between them and seemingly oblivious to your presence.



Standing between a pair of pillars, another statue holds a cracked seal in its hands. A ten-foot-deep dais to the north rises six feet above the floor, lit by a magical torch and reached by a short flight of steps. A brazier stands at the center of the dais, with a bas relief of a set of Kelemvor scales carved above it. Oddly, the scales are tipped to the left, where Kelemvor's symbol normally shows them in balance. A large brass key is set into the wall beneath the symbol.

ZOMBIE DINERS

With a fresh meal in front of them, the two **zombies** ignore the party's fight with the skeletons, not attacking until the first character approaches to within 10 feet of the northernmost statue, or if they are attacked first. For a 4th-level party, use four zombies. For a 5th-level party, use six zombies.

STAIR TRAP

At the top of the stairs, a hidden pressure plate triggers a mechanical trap. Any creature that steps on the trap causes a cluster of spikes to shoot up into their feet, and must make a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw. On a failed